Grounded

CLEAR THINKING AND RESILIENCE FOR DEMANDING WORK



ISSUE 2 · NOVEMBER 2026

Protecting Your Focus in a Day Full of Interruptions

— Know what deserves your best hours
— Batch the small stuff
— Make interruptions less costly

By Dr. Solomon Chukwuemeka Awusah (Non-Clinical Strategist) · solomonawusah.com

Protecting Your Focus in a Day Full of Interruptions

Messages, meetings and requests compete for attention all day. A few practical habits help protect the time needed for the work that matters most.

By Dr. Solomon Chukwuemeka Awusah (Non-Clinical Strategist) · November 7, 2026

Know what deserves your best hours

Most people have certain times of day when their thinking feels clearest. For some it is early morning, for others late afternoon. Those hours are valuable, and they are often spent on email and routine tasks simply because those arrive first.

A better approach is to identify the one or two pieces of work each day that require careful thought, and to schedule them for the hours when attention is strongest. Routine tasks can fill the remaining time without much loss.

Protecting those hours may mean declining some early meetings or moving them later in the day. Treating focused work as a real appointment, rather than something squeezed in between other commitments, makes it far more likely to happen.

Batch the small stuff

Checking messages every few minutes feels productive, but it breaks attention into small fragments. Each switch between tasks carries a cost: it takes time to remember where you were and to settle back into the work.

Grouping similar tasks together reduces that cost. Responding to messages at set times, returning calls in a single block and handling paperwork in one sitting lets the rest of the day stay more continuous.

Turning off nonessential notifications supports this approach. Most messages can wait an hour without any harm, and the few that are truly urgent usually arrive through a phone call or a direct visit anyway.

Make interruptions less costly

Some interruptions cannot be avoided, especially for leaders and managers who need to be available to their teams. The goal is not to eliminate them but to make

them easier to recover from.

A simple habit helps: before responding to an interruption, take a few seconds to jot down where you were and what the next step was going to be. When you return, that note makes it much faster to pick up the thread.

Set clear signals for others

Colleagues often interrupt because they cannot tell when someone is available. Clear signals help. A calendar block labeled for focused work, a status message, or a regular open-door hour lets people know when to reach out and when to wait.

Most teams respect these boundaries once they are explained. They also tend to adopt similar habits themselves, which raises the focus of the whole group.

Leaders can help by agreeing on shared norms, such as which channels are for urgent matters and which can be answered later in the day.

Close loops before switching

Unfinished tasks have a way of pulling attention back to them. Before moving on to something new, it helps to bring the current task to a clean stopping point, even if the work is not complete. Saving a draft, writing down the next step or sending a quick update can free the mind to move on fully.

Keeping a single trusted list of open commitments supports this habit. When every task has a place to live outside your head, it becomes easier to set one aside without worrying that it will be forgotten.

End the day with a short reset

A few minutes at the end of each workday can make the next morning far more focused. Reviewing what was accomplished, noting what remains and choosing the first task for tomorrow means the day starts with direction rather than with the inbox.

This short routine also creates a clearer boundary between work and the rest of the evening, which supports steadier attention over the course of a demanding week.

A brief weekly version of the same review, looking back at the past five days and ahead to the next five, helps keep larger priorities from being crowded out by daily urgencies.

Focus as a practice

Focus is not a fixed trait that some people have and others lack. It is shaped by daily choices: when to do demanding work, how to group small tasks, how to recover from interruptions, how to signal availability and how to close each day.

None of these habits require special tools. Practiced consistently, they help turn a scattered day into one with room for the work that matters.

Read online at https://solomonawusah.com/grounded/issues/issue-02.html